

■ By Damayanti Datta

—“I am fat ugly girl, huh? and how the hell am I manly?”

—“Hey!! that's just the truth. just like there are pretty people, there are ugly ones. and u r one of the ugly ones...”

—“I am hot and skinny...you're the broad shouldered, ugly haired, “girl”...”

They don't know each other. They have never met. They certainly have no reason to hate each other. But their lives have just crossed on a social network site. They have taken a peek at (and an instant dislike to) each other's posted photographs and decided to comment on that most personal and sensitive of issues—each other's bodily ‘imperfections’. “Just a girl feeling bitchy at 6 p.m.,” signs off Sareeta, one of the challengers on MySpace.

If only. To Internet trend-spotters, however, they were doing much more. They were unwittingly engaging in an emerging public sport, ‘bodysnarking’, a word that stands for the everyday sarcasm-laced jibes directed at women, mostly by women—especially on the Net. The word combines, “snide” and “remark”. Add “body” to it and the concept takes nastiness to new heights. Its primary targets, and also most enthusiastic participants, are usually young females and mostly those who are into social networking hubs, photo-sharing services and blogs—Facebook, Orkut, YouTube, MySpace to name a few. With it all, spiteful, if witty, comments are becoming an insidious part of female conversation on the digital domain.

Sushmita Banerjee, a 32-year-old from Mumbai, woke up to bodysnarking when she posted some post-pregnancy photographs on her Facebook page. Within days, those unflattering, button-popping photographs had been blasted with random, often anonymous comments. “I was shocked at the deluge of hyper-critical, ‘Oh my God, you are so fat,’ type of remarks,” she says. Somebody even posted, “Have you ever tried lipo? What about gastric bypass?” Most of these people making negative comments were women and some were ‘friends’. “Remarking on someone's appearance was once considered déclassé, at least publicly,” says Banerjee. “But it's now being done on blogs, social networks and YouTube with the same effortlessness as sending an SMS,” she adds.

Welcome to a flat world. The World Wide Web is now the driving force, community is the byword and collaboration the mantra. But it's also an age when millions of people are coming together, digital camera in hand (how else would you share your precious moments with the world?) and getting a venue for posting their opinions on anything and everything. And dissecting other

women's looks—from fun holiday photographs to clandestinely-snapped images of strangers caught at vulnerable moments—is turning out to be a favourite female pastime. It does not matter if you are a size eight or a size zero. If your photograph is on the Net, be ready for a bit of nasty nitpicking: “those love handles are dreadful”, “saggy butts are definitely not hot”, “not even on my worst days have I looked like that”.

Whatever happened to good, old feminine solidarity? Catch the buzz on the Net. Even men are concerned: “It's like for UNKNOWN reason they just step up and be very mean to one another,” writes one bloke on Orkut. “I wonder if it's the lack of attention,” speculates another. “Girls tend to use psychological games,” he clarifies. “It's the pack thing,” posts yet another. “They don't like women with high self-esteem as they are threats. They pick on loners and outsiders as they are easy targets. So, be confident, girls! Love yourself! Think positive! Don't be pushed around! Life may not be a bitch after all!” The discussion is wound up by HAHAAHAHA, who says, “Welcome to life...sometimes women need no reason...sometimes too much, and mostly...who knows...”.

IT'S COOL TO BE BITCHY. THE TYPE OF GIRLS WHO LOVE TO BE ‘BAD’, AND ARE PROUD OF THE TAG, IS RISING.

“It's cool to be bitchy,” holds 18-year-old Nidhi of Hansraj College in Delhi. She is not into all this (“I don't like the road-rage kind of exchanges on the Internet”). But the type of girls who love to be ‘bad’, and are proud of the tag, is increasing, she feels. “By being a bitch, by passing a nasty comment on those you hate, or even those you don't, you can stand out in the crowd.” If you look bad in a photograph, you will be tagged ‘Hahaha’. To avoid that label, the pressure to look good on social network sites goes up tremendously and vanity becomes the byword. “I know girls who put in pictures of their face taken from all angles on social network sites.” The most feared word among girls, not surprisingly, is “fugly”—a combination of fat and ugly—she says.

It's a cultural moment that Shelja Sen, consultant psychologist with Sitaram Bhartiya Institute of Science and Research in Delhi, characterises as a time of “unshackled celebration of bitchiness”, especially among young women. “I'm quite struck by the kind of language they use—‘bitch’, ‘shithead’ or ‘scumbag’—to friends and in personal relationships and the level of desensitisation to abusive words.” It is part and parcel of a type of ‘politics’ that girls start from a very